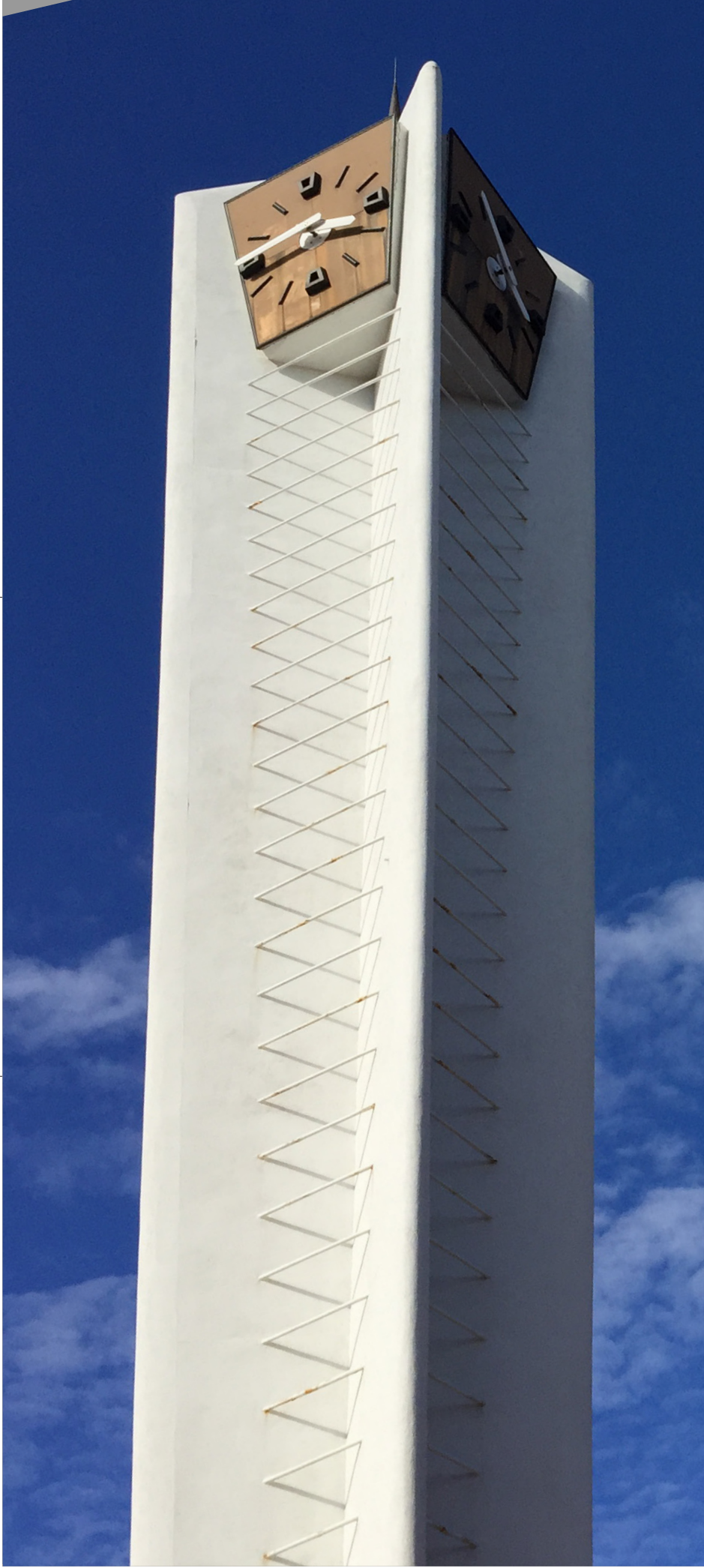


BELLVILLE, SA

FIELD WORK LOOKING INTO MARKET DYNAMICS IN BELLVIEL, CAPE TOWN

CREATED AS PART OF THE NEW SCHOOL RESEARCH GROUP FOR INTERNATIONAL AFFAIRS

SUMMER 2017



Re-Imagining Regeneration in Bellville, South Africa: Informality, Security, and the Realities of Transit-Oriented Spatial Restructuring

Bellville operates as the secondary Central Business District (CBD) of the City of Cape Town and the primary urban hub of the Voortrekker Road Corridor Integration Zone (VRCIZ). While top-down municipal planning strategies envision Bellville as a high-density, Transit-Oriented Development (TOD) core, on-the-ground socioeconomic realities reveal a complex urban ecosystem characterized by informal tent markets, migrant economies, security-driven spatial policing, and socio-spatial displacement.

Figure 1: Area covered during the field work, same as the plans to build the peatonal corridor



1. Policy Context and Spatial Framework

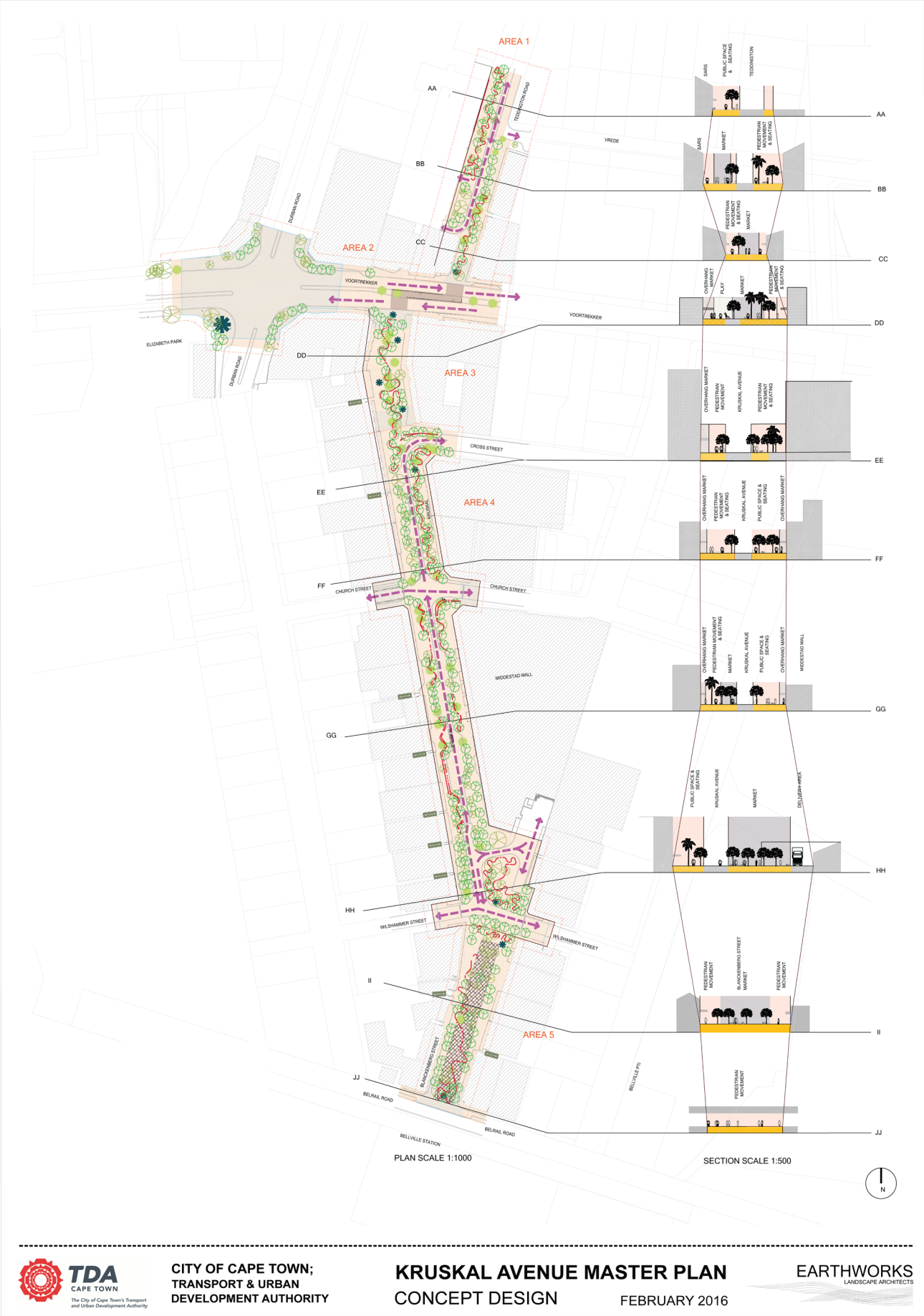
Introduction

Urban policy for the Voortrekker Road Corridor (VRC) is anchored in municipal frameworks such as the Built Environment Performance Plan (BEPP 2016/17), the Cape Town Spatial Development Framework (CTSDF 2012), the Comprehensive Integrated Transport Plan (CITP 2013–2018), and the Urban Land Institute (ULI) Advisory Panel Report. These documents frame Bellville as the pivotal eastern anchor of the Urban Core Corridor, intended to balance the spatial distribution of economic activity between the northern and southern sub-regions of Cape Town.

The Municipal Spatial Development Framework outlines several **key structural dynamics for Bellville**:

- **SDF 22 & 35:** Highlights the intensification potential along the existing rail corridor and the strategic Blue Downs Rail Link, intended to integrate the Metro South-East with Bellville. [cite: 1, 4]
- **SDF 24:** Notes the historical clustering of insurance, business, and financial services within the Bellville CBD, while heavy industrial uses have been displaced peripherally. [cite: 1, 4]
- **SDF 257:** Documents the migration of primary A-grade retail and corporate office space away from the Bellville CBD toward Tyger Valley, leaving the Bellville core dominated by public sector institutions, informal trade, and service-sector activities in urgent need of capital investment.

- **SDF 27:** Notes that the informal sector absorbs approximately 11% of the metro’s workforce, requiring dedicated municipal support for Small, Medium, and Micro Enterprises (SMMEs) [cite: 1, 4]
- UN-Habitat’s urban paradigm argues for inverting the conventional relationship between economic development and urban planning: rather than assuming that wealth creation passively produces good cities, well-coordinated public space and urban structure must be leveraged as the active primary driver of economic development. Within spontaneous urbanization, the proportion of public to private space is frequently less than 1:10. In Bellville, the scarcest resource is not capital, but spatial coordination. Top-down municipal investments in heavy transit infrastructure (such as the Bellville Public Transport Interchange, which handles 108,676 daily commuters) risk being misleading if they assume transport alone automatically triggers urban intensification. Without urban space facilitation, high transit costs burden lower-income populations before the required population concentration and local economic vitality are established. [cite: 2]



2. Empirical Baseline: Micro-Economy, Formality, and Built Conditions

Field surveys across 253 commercial and retail entities in the Bellville CBD core provide a granular baseline of the local built environment, business mix, and operational conditions.

Hues of Formality and Market Temporality

The informal market economy comprises 22.9% of the surveyed retail footprint, operating entirely out of temporary tarp and tent structures concentrated along Kruskal Avenue and the Bellville Station precinct. Of these 58 informal units, 87.9% (51 units) trade in low-cost apparel, alongside Snoek fishmongers and convenience food vendors. Rather than relying on private security firms, 100% of the informal traders rely on communal self-policing (“Trader Community”) and shared overnight storage networks.

Financial Vulnerability and Credit InfrastructureA notable feature of the formal and semi-formal commercial landscape is the density of debt consolidation programs, micro-lending offices, small-business startup financing, and prominent “lay-away” payment displays in retail shopfronts. This points to a local consumer base operating under financial strain, relying on credit structures to purchase basic consumer goods. Physical banking infrastructure reflects heightened security awareness, featuring exterior or semi-interior ATM lobbies guarded by private security personnel.Migrant Urbanism and Enclave EconomiesThe survey identifies specialized commercial enclaves, such as Somali-operated multi-story business and

residential hubs providing community-based retail, services, and housing. Similarly, specific commercial nodes cater directly to the local Muslim population, demonstrating how space is organized around socio-cultural networks rather than top-down zoning logic alone.

Figure 3: Example of mixed used buildings surveyed in Bellville



Figure 4: Example of parameters used for the survey

Living quarters

Money
Cheques

Food

Communal
Rooms



3. Core Urban Issues: Informality, Criminality, Gentrification, and Displacement

Informality and the Rigid Narrative of Permanence

Municipal plans frequently exhibit a strict vision of the “formal” as permanent, concrete, and tax-paying. This creates a narrative gap that criminalizes or seeks to eliminate informal trade. Informal markets answer to temporal, flexible dynamics that require fluidity rather than fixed physical infrastructure. The current informal tent markets along Kruskal Avenue operate on precise daily and weekly rhythms. Forcing these traders into rigid, permanent formal structures risks destroying the low-overhead, adaptive logic that allows them to survive.

Criminality, Spatial Security, and the “Clearing at 5 PM” Phenomenon

Security regimes in Bellville significantly impact urban vitality. A pervasive “social code” and active security enforcement clear informal traders and close retail storefronts by 5:00 PM. While intended to curb crime and grime, this aggressive evening shutdown harms street vitality, creates dead edge effects, and reinforces perceptions of danger after dark. Furthermore, formal security approaches clash with informal mechanisms: while formal retail relies on private guards, perimeter bars, and exterior ATM security, informal traders rely on spatial porosity, foot traffic, and communal vigilance.

Gentrification, Land Values, and Socio-Spatial Displacement

Regeneration plans along the Voortrekker Road Corridor, paired with major public transport interchange (PTI) upgrades and Transit-

Oriented Development (TOD) incentives, threaten to inflate land values around Kruskal Avenue and Bellville Station. Spatial GIS mapping indicates a sharp value divide between expensive plots along the station/Kruskal core and lower-value surrounding lots. Unmitigated TOD land-value capture risks pricing out SMMEs, informal vendors, and migrant entrepreneurs, driving gentrification and physical displacement toward un-serviced peripheral areas.

Partial Citizenship and Indirect Spatial Relations

Many informal operators, particularly international migrants, experience “partial citizenship”—they contribute directly to Bellville’s street vitality and local economy, yet possess an indirect, precarious relationship to formal urban space. Regeneration narratives framed around “regeneration,” “vitality,” and “transit-oriented development” often raise the question: integration for whom? When formal urban visioning prioritizes ribbon-cutting aesthetics over inclusive socio-economic dynamics, marginal populations bear the brunt of displacement.



Figure 5: Revealing the tension bewtween policy and the survey

Figure 6: Results from the survey summarized

PARAMETER SURVEY zoning · typology · condition · activity			
PARAMETER / CATEGORY	METRIC / COUNT	VALUE	PERCENTAGE / SHARE
ZONING DISTRIBUTION			
Commercial	126	—	49.8%
Mixed-Use (Commercial/Residential)	63	—	24.9%
Informal (Tarp / Tent Structures)	58	—	22.9%
Government / Institutional	3	—	1.2%
Single Residential	2	—	0.8%
Non-Profit / Organization	1	—	0.4%
BUILDING TYPOLOGY			
1-Story Permanent Structure	99	—	39.1%
Temporary Tarp / Tent Structure	58	—	22.9%
2-Story Structure	35	—	13.8%
3-Story Structure	21	—	8.3%
5-Story Structure	13	—	5.1%
4-Story Structure	7	—	2.8%
6+ Story High-Rise / Tower	5	—	2.0%
BUILDING CONDITION			
Fair Condition	89	—	37.7%
Informal (Temporary Material)	58	—	24.6%
Good Condition	50	—	21.2%
Excellent Condition	20	—	8.5%
Poor / Dilapidated	15	—	6.4%
PRIMARY ACTIVITY TYPE			
Apparel & Clothing	78	—	32.9%
Food & Takeaway Dining	28	—	11.8%
General Retail	22	—	9.3%
Financial Services / Debt Lending	17	—	7.2%
Personal Services & Electronics	27	—	11.4%
Health, Beauty, & Entertainment	30	—	12.7%
SECURITY ARCHITECTURE			
Private Formal Security (Guards/Bars)	89	—	57.4% of surveyed
Trader Community Self-Policing	58	—	37.4% of surveyed
ⓘ Security shares based on surveyed structures (n≈155).			
field survey · all categories · square format			



Seen from above, the urban fabric of Bellville's commercial core, a mosaic-like canopy of the informal tent market along the Kruskal Avenue corridor. A dense, patchwork of fifty-eight plastic tarpaulins, stretched canvas, and temporary structures clings to the pedestrian arteries, weaving tightly between solid commercial blocks. Adaptively claim the street, creating a living, breathing landscape of temporal commerce right at the doorstep of the Bellville transport interchange.

4. Policy Recommendations:

Diagramming Responsive Regeneration

Rather than enforcing rigid, top-down master plans, municipal intervention should adopt flexible spatial diagrams thataccommodatethe “hues of formality” and foster genuine urban resilience.

Transition Management and Temporal Market Infrastructure

- Consultation and Process: Redesign of the Bellville Station and Kruskal Avenue precincts must embed structured consultation with informal trader associations.
- Temporal Spatial Allocation: Establish flexible street layouts (“diagrams rather than fixed plans”) that permit temporary tarp market structures during peak trading hours, supported by municipal installation of water, electricity, and waste points.
- Communal Asset Storage: Construct secure, shared overnight storage facilities within the station precinct to eliminate trader transport overheads.

Rethinking Urban Security and Street Vitality

- Extending Operational Windows: Shift urban management away from forced 5:00 PM street clearings. Introduce staggered evening trading permits, improved street lighting, and active ground-floor interfaces to foster an evening economy.
- Co-Managed Precinct Security: Integrate formal Special Rating Area (SRA) / City Improvement District (CID) security patrols with informal “Trader Community” self-policing networks to build mutual trust and reduce crime without criminalizing trade.

Inclusive TOD and Anti-Displacement Safeguards

- Affordable Commercial & Housing Allocation: Municipal land releases around Bellville Station, Paint City, and surrounding public parcels must mandate inclusionary quotas for SMME incubators, low-cost rental units, and social housing managed by Social Housing Institutions (SHIs).
- Public Space Ratios: Adhere to UN-Habitat public space guidelines, maintaining a public-to-private space ratio of at least 1:3 within newly intensified TOD nodes to ensure spatial accessibility for informal economic activities.

Bridging Policy Narratives via Research and Participatory Governance

- Reframing Formality: Update municipal Economic Area Management Programme (ECAMP) and Built Environment Performance Plan (BEPP) indicators to recognize informal trade as an essential component of urban resilience rather than an indicator of decay.
- Stakeholder Roundtables: Institutionalize a permanent Bellville Urban Management Forum comprising the City (SPUD, TCT), the Greater Tygerberg Partnership (GTP), formal property owners, informal trader representatives, and migrant business associations.

PROPOSED STRATEGIC INTERVENTIONS

1. TRANSITION MANAGEMENT & TEMPORAL SUPPORT

- Designated flexible zoning for tent markets along Kruskal Ave.
- Communal overnight storage facilities & basic utility hookups.

2. SECURITY REFORM & EVENING ECONOMY ACTIVATION

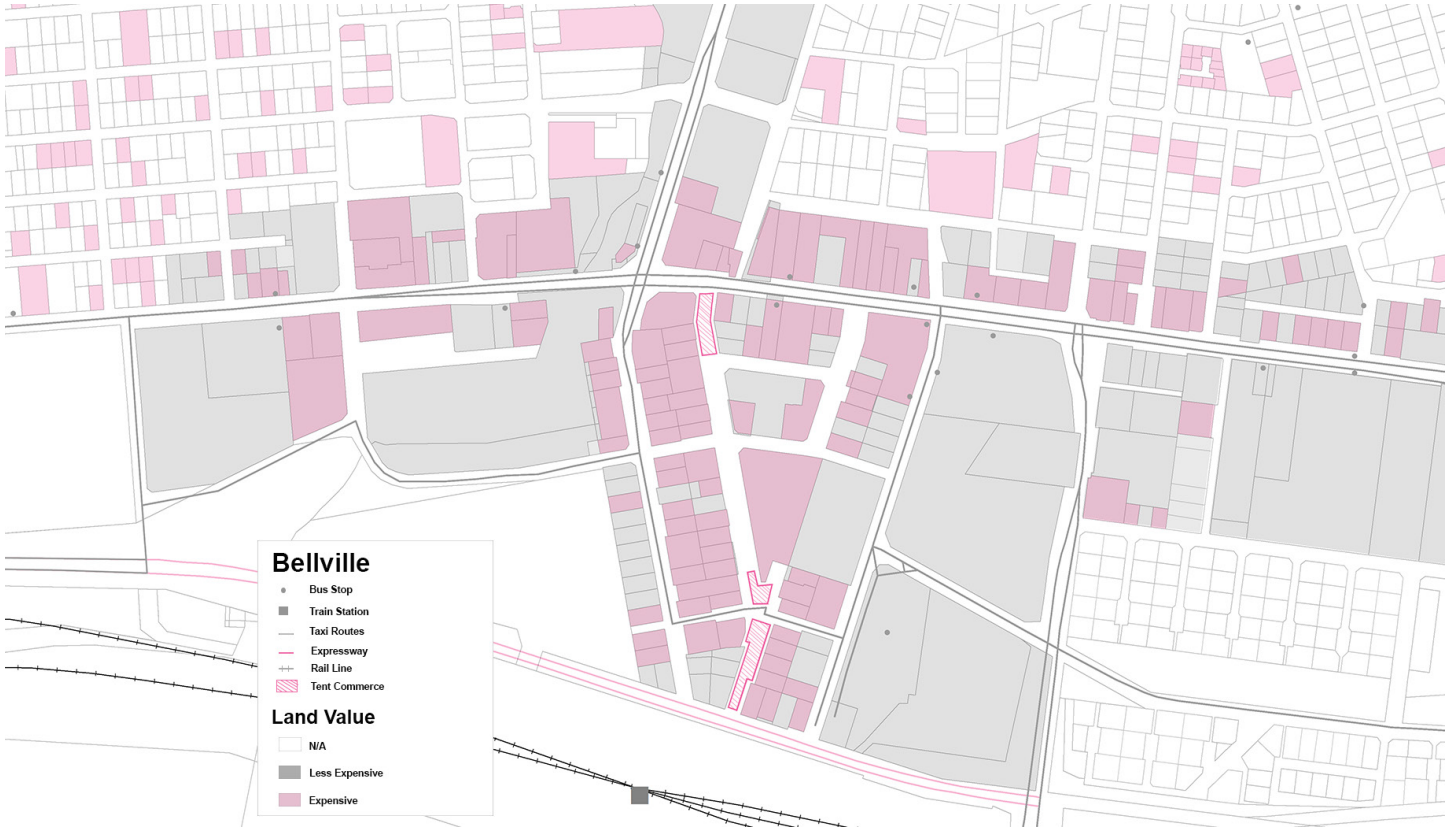
- Replace "clearing at 5 PM" with active lighting & night-market permits.
- Co-management security models combining CID guards & trader networks.

3. INCLUSIVE TOD & ANTI-DISPLACEMENT SAFEGUARDS

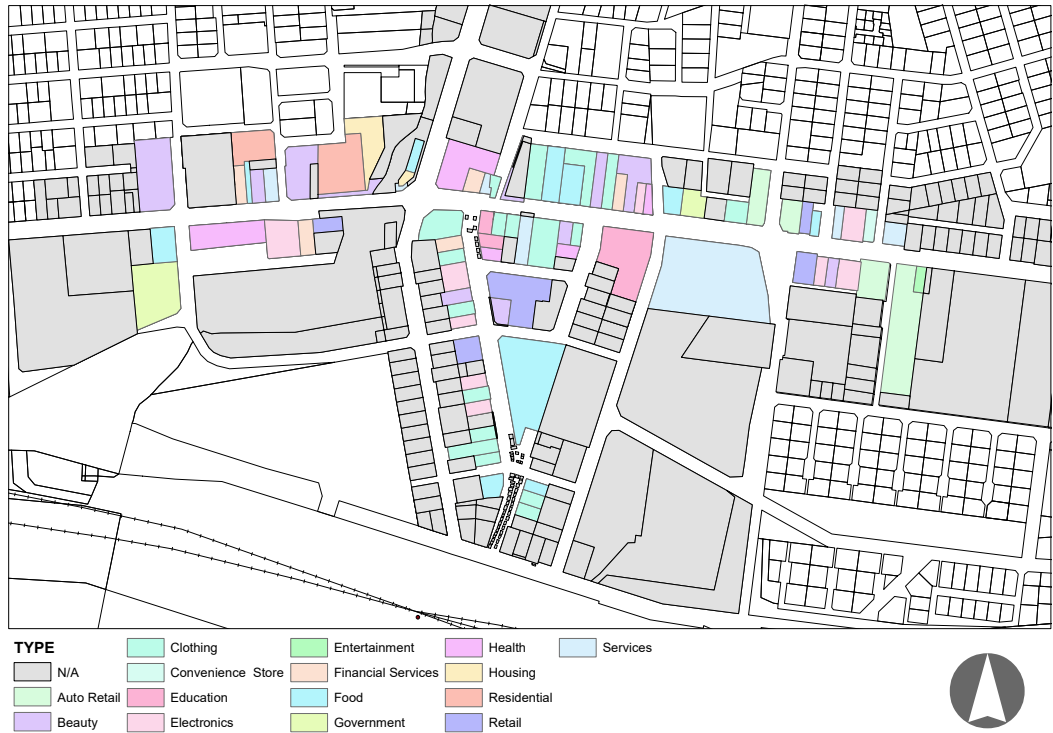
- Mandate 1:10 public space ratio & affordable retail/incubator slots.
- Proactive land assembly for social housing & micro-trader hubs.

4. INSTITUTIONAL COORDINATION & PARTICIPATORY GOVERNANCE

- Establish Bellville Developer & Trader Roundtable.
- Multi-departmental coordination (SPUD, TCT, Property Management).



Map 1: Context of the area and Land Value



Map 2: Results from the survey and type of store



APPENDIX SURVEY MAPS

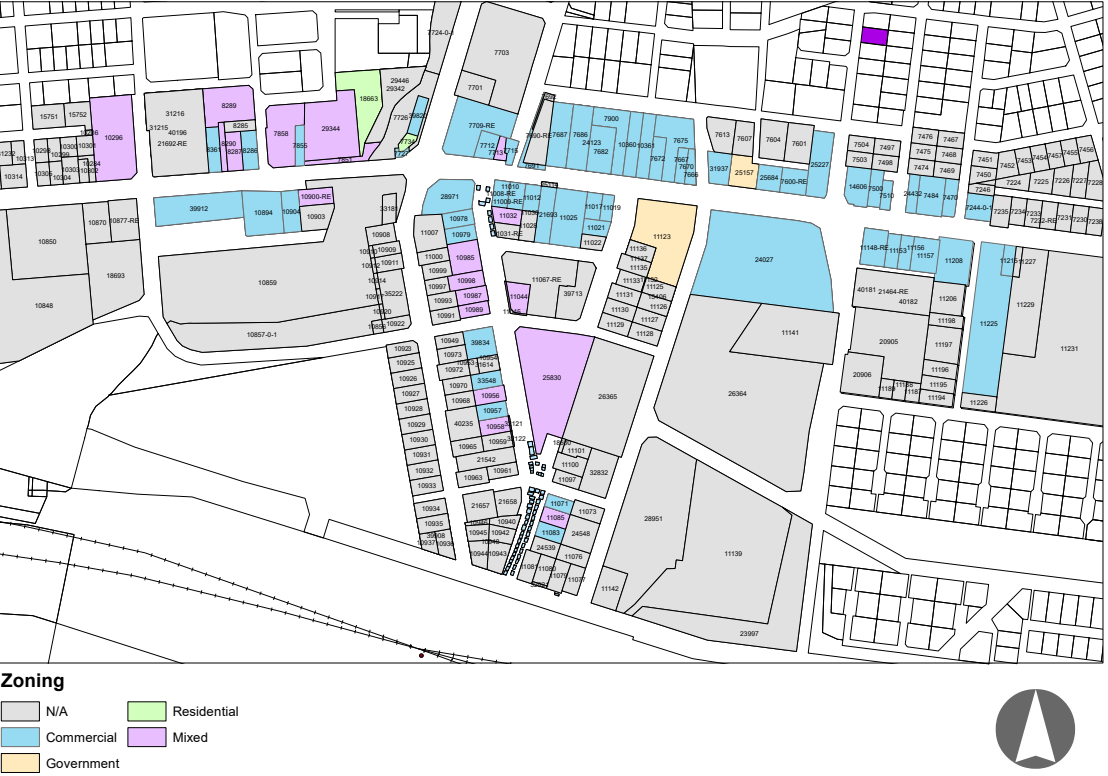
MAP 3: CONDITION OF BUILDINGS



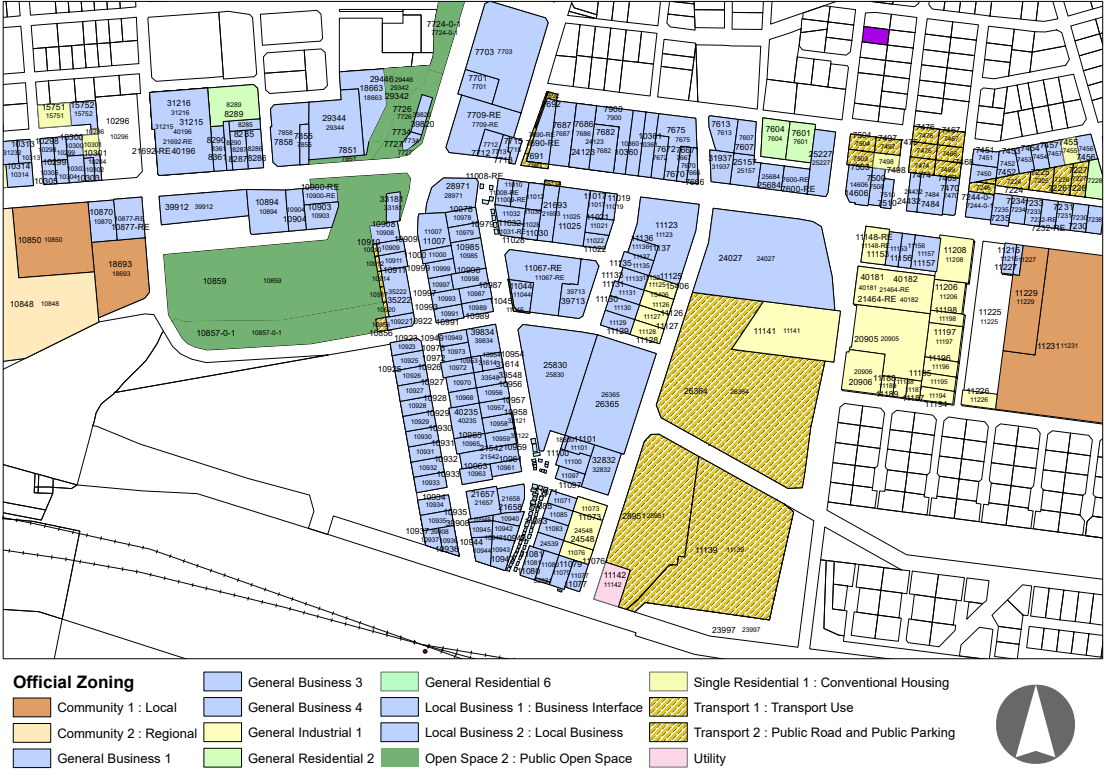
MAP 5: OCUPATION OF THE BUILDING



MAP 4: USE OF THE BUILDING



MAP 6: OFFICIAL ZONING



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